



Submitted via electronic mail ([REDACTED])

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March 14, 2025

Faisal D'Souza
National Coordination Office
Networking and Information Technology Research and Development (NITRD)
2415 Eisenhower Avenue
Alexandria, VA 22314

Re: *Request for Information on the Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan*

Dear Mr. D'Souza,

On behalf of OCHIN, we thank you for the opportunity to respond to the Networking and Information Technology Research and Development (NITRD) National Coordination Office's (NCO) request for information (RFI) on the *Development of an Artificial Intelligence (AI) Action Plan* ("Plan") on behalf of the Office of Science and Technology Policy (OSTP). We applaud the Administration efforts to strengthen America's AI capabilities, ensuring that innovation remains at the forefront while upholding the principles of security and transparency. The United States stands at an inflection point in global AI leadership. While flagship health care centers are adopting AI to improve health outcomes and reduce cost, crucial gaps remain in rural and low resourced communities, which comprise a significant portion of the nation's infrastructure, workforce, and economic potential. **For the US to continue its global leadership in AI, health care providers in rural and low resourced communities must have the tools needed to participate in AI as active contributors and innovators.**

OCHIN: DRIVING INNOVATION, COST-EFFICIENCY, AND SELF-SUFFICIENCY

OCHIN is a **national nonprofit health information technology and research network** that serves more than 300 independent organizations with 2,000 health care delivery sites in 42 states. For over two decades, OCHIN has provided technology solutions, informatics, evidence-based research, and policy insights for critical access hospitals (CAHs), rural emergency hospitals (REHs), rural and frontier health clinics, community health centers, and federally qualified health centers (FQHCs).

With 25 years of experience, we have seen firsthand how investing in cutting-edge technology empowers providers to offer higher-quality, data-driven care while protecting patient information from cyber threats, including malicious foreign actors. For example, in the OCHIN

network, we prioritize the use of AI to simplify documentation; tailor communication and translate clinical questionnaires; provide chart summaries; and automate actions like imaging follow-ups.

UNLEASHING AI'S POTENTIAL IN RURAL AND LOW RESOURCED COMMUNITIES IN AMERICA

Rural and low resourced communities are sitting on untapped potential, and AI will be the catalyst for transformation.

- Rural and low resourced communities need investments in AI infrastructure and readiness to drive America's next wave of tech-driven prosperity.
- Health care providers often are among the largest employers in these communities making AI investments a direct engine of financial health among local and regional employers.
- Investing in AI means fueling job creation, attracting top talent, and modernizing essential services—all while enhancing patient care and superior AI systems.
- Without modernized health IT infrastructure, health care providers cannot fully participate in AI-driven advancements, putting them—and the broader US economy—at a competitive disadvantage.
- AI is already transforming diagnostics, predictive analytics, and operational efficiency but providers in rural and low resourced areas operating with outdated systems and razor-thin margins cannot leverage these innovations.
- **Without targeted investments, they will become AI deserts**—falling behind on cybersecurity, workforce readiness, and economic growth.

AI models trained on narrow range of health care settings limit their predictive power and commercial viability.

- When AI systems are built using data from only large academic institutions, they struggle to perform reliably in other environments, such as rural hospitals which have different workflows, staffing levels, and patient health needs.
- This weakens AI's predictive power and undermines its potential for solving specific challenges and driving dramatically improved outcomes.
- To build robust globally competitive AI systems, **all providers, especially those in rural and low resourced areas, must be integrated into AI development, validation, deployment, and monitoring.**

A strong, resilient nation requires secure, AI-ready health care systems across all health care providers.

- With the rapid acceleration of AI across all sectors, **we risk leaving providers in rural and low resourced areas behind if they do not receive investments to upgrade critical infrastructure** and defend against cyber threats.
- To counter escalating cyber threats posed by criminal organizations and foreign actors, we must harden health care infrastructure, cultivate the next wave of cybersecurity and AI talent, and invest in scalable, self-reliant solutions.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Equip Providers in Rural and Low resourced Areas with Modern AI-Ready Health IT Systems

Recommendation: *Repurpose and streamline existing funding programs, such as the USDA Community Grant Program under the Farm Bill, to equip providers in rural and low resourced communities with modernized health IT systems. Further, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention received significant funding to modernize health IT systems, but local providers including those in rural communities have not been eligible to access these funds.*

- Providers in rural and low resourced areas have minimal capital for health IT infrastructure modernization, yet this is the very infrastructure they need to transition to financial sustainability and practice transformation that will drive vastly improved outcomes.
- U.S. global leadership in AI depends on modern, interoperable, and secure IT systems that allow all providers to participate in AI-driven development and deployment.
- AI-ready certified, hosted, and maintained health IT systems can expedite patient care, improve financial optimization, reduce waste and repetition, and drive exponential improvements in patient care.

Fund AI Readiness and Cybersecurity to Secure U.S. Health Care Infrastructure

Recommendation: *Invest in integrated AI and cybersecurity readiness to ensure that providers in rural and low resourced communities have the skills, technical assistance, and tools to acquire, validate, deploy, scale, and monitor AI systems.*

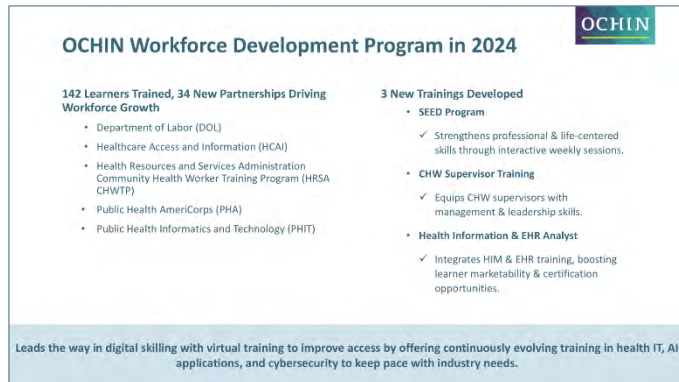
- AI readiness must include essential cybersecurity tools for risk assessments, audits and secure AI model deployment, along with cybersecurity insurance to protect health care infrastructure.
- Cyberattacks cost providers over \$10 million per incident, often forcing closures—far exceeding the costs of preventive security measures that range from \$50,000-\$250,000 annually.
- Strategic investments in prevention will yield high returns by avoiding breaches, maintaining clinical operations, and protecting patient care.
- Certified hosted and maintained health IT systems are a critical part of the equation as they include multi-factor authentication, encryption, and automated security protocols which will reduce costs and improve cybersecurity resilience.



Leverage AI as a Job Creator

Recommendation: *Disrupt and redesign workforce development and training by shifting to skills-based training, replacing outdated apprenticeship models designed for traditional trades.*

- Legacy training models do not support rapid, modular learning necessary for AI adoption.
- Training models must power upskilling for the entire health care team with career ladders and continuous learning.
- AI-driven health IT roles can create economic opportunities, strengthen local talent pipelines, and build financial stability and prosperity for rural and low resourced communities.
- These regions can become hubs for AI-drive health care innovation, fueling job growth in cybersecurity, AI governance, health IT, and bioinformatics.
- Recruiting and training local talent supports economic resilience and strengthens U.S. competitiveness.
- AI workforce investments create high-paying sustainable jobs, attract top talent, and solidify the U.S. as a global AI leader.
- OCHIN offers a workforce development program that creates opportunities by leveraging flexible, virtual training combined with practical, hands-on job experience.
 - For too long, the main route into health care is with a university degree, but that is massively expensive and time intensive.
 - We offer a **lower-cost, more flexible and faster option** to train people with the skills they need to succeed in high demand jobs.
 - This means more people—including rural residents living far from universities—can access these trainings and obtain jobs in healthcare to support themselves and their families.
 - Together, OCHIN and our members collaborate with federal, state and local partners to provide market-driven, new health IT, and community health training that will transform the health and economies of communities across the country.
 - These skills are critical for preventing and managing chronic disease, driving down the cost of care, and achieving greater efficiency in how health care operates.



Harness Local AI Validation to Strengthen AI Performance and Market Viability

Recommendation: *Prioritize investments in learning networks that facilitate local validation, ensuring AI tools perform effectively across deployment settings.*

- AI models trained on incomplete or narrow data lead to inaccuracies, inefficiencies, and reduced effectiveness—eroding the potential of AI transformation and global competitiveness.
- Strong AI development requires robust data and real-world testing in different operating environments.
- Local validation ensures AI models are tested under real-world deployment conditions, improving accuracy and usability.
- AI models can degrade in performance over time, making ongoing monitoring and evaluation critical to maintain reliability.

Expand Cybersecurity Capacity with Non-Profit Health IT Collaboratives

Recommendation: *Invest in shared cybersecurity and AI capacity through non-profit collaboratives while aligning AI, privacy, and cybersecurity frameworks.*

- Non-profit health IT collaboratives allow providers in rural and low resourced communities to leverage economies of scale, reduce costs, and maintain operational continuity during crises.
- Supporting shared infrastructure reduces duplicative costs, further shared learnings, and drives rapid cycle learning.

Support Industry Consensus Standards and Frameworks to Drive National Uniformity

Recommendation: *Promote a stakeholder-driven consensus-based approach to AI digital data, cybersecurity, and privacy standards while streamlining regulatory processes.*

- A nationally coordinated, industry-led approach to digital data, cybersecurity, and privacy standards is critical for AI adoption in health care.
- Conflicting federal and state regulations create a fragmented systems that slows innovation, increases compliance burdens, and weakens AI competitiveness.
- Without a harmonized framework, providers—especially in rural and low resourced communities—face unnecessary barriers to AI adoption due to inconsistent digital data, cybersecurity, and privacy requirements.
- Championing national standards, such as the U.S. Code Data for Interoperability (USCDI), to drive data standardization, eliminates roadblocks that stifle innovation.
- Supporting initiatives that leverage the leadership of industry like the CISA Health Sector Coordinating Council (HSCC), which develops scalable, health-specific cybersecurity frameworks tailored to the needs of providers in rural and low resourced communities.

Incorporate a Risk-based Approach to AI Regulation in Health Care

Recommendation: *Adopt recommendations for a risk-based approach in regulating AI in the health care sector to balance innovation with patient safety.*

- AI oversight in health care specifically should align with three factors:
 - **Transparency:** Clear documentation of model development, data resources, risk mitigation, and performance

- **Intended Use and Conditions of Deployment:** Identify AI functions whether administrative, research, or clinical decision-making and where these will be deployed.
- **Level of autonomy:** Determine level of human oversight, from in the loop, on the loop, or out of the loop.
- Autonomous AI used in clinical decision-making (e.g., diagnostics, predictive analysis) that lacks transparency requires greater oversight than administrative or research applications that are assistive or augmentative and that are fully transparent, for example.
- A tiered regulatory approach ensures appropriate oversight for high-risk AI without overburdening low-risk applications.
- It should also include clear AI risk classifications, cross-agency regulatory alignment, local real-world validation initiatives, and incentives for safety-by-design principles to balance patient safety with AI advancement.

CONCLUSION

America's AI future depends on secure, modern infrastructure and strategic investment in rural and low resourced communities. By advancing AI-drive modernization, strengthening cybersecurity, and expanding workforce development, we can enhance economic growth, improve health care, and ensure the nation remains at the forefront of AI innovation. **We urge the Administration to consider these recommendations for inclusion in its Plan and take decisive action to equip these communities with the tools and resources needed to fully participate in and benefit from AI advancements.**

Please contact me at [REDACTED] if we can provide any additional information to support your efforts.

Sincerely,

Jennifer Stoll
Chief External Affairs Officer